

Hello. I am going to talk about using computer games to salvage thought experiments in ethics.

By a thought experiment I mean an experiment that you only imagine doing, such as the trolley experiment. I do have a problem with resorting to such thought experiments without any regulations, because they easily get out of control, to the extent that after some point taking them seriously becomes impossible. Thus we need some way of regulating which thought experiments are to be used in ethical inquiries. For the sake of argument I am going to be focusing on the good old trolley experiment.

Just to showcase the absurdity I am talking about, here are two of many variations of the trolley experiment presented by Kamm. I would presume that it would be very weird to talk about ethical dilemmas when you are actually holding a grenade.

Let me be more specific about what the problem with using thought experiments is: they simply fail at being good toy examples, and they do so in two different aspects. First, they can't isolate the intended ethical dilemma efficiently, and second citing them automatically suppresses the temporal urgency to make a decision built-in the experiments. And to be clear, these two are at the heart of their utility, hence my problem. Both of these problems stem from the fact that such a thought experiment is based on a physical possibility, meaning that it can occur as an observable physical phenomenon: I can, by some odd chance, find myself as the driver that faces the choice of killing five versus killing one, all the while holding a grenade. (By the way what you see here is called a "spherical cow": it's a pun on theoretical physics oversimplifying real phenomena.)

So I propose to invoke a gameplay possibility instead of a physical possibility. To be sure, this requires some understanding of basic game design, and it forces one to flesh out just enough details required for the experiment to be taken seriously. This is indeed a possible solution because a gameworld requires some abstraction from reality by default. Juul claims that "abstraction can be seen as the process by which any given subject matter is transformed into game form.", and that "the level of abstraction is the level on which the player can act: The actions that are available to the player.". So the two said issues are addressed. Further, computer games can be made to be "ethically notable" by way of implementing ethical dilemmas. The notion of ethical game design is established by Sicart, who claims that "any object can be designed with a value system in mind, and that those values can be imprinted in the very design of the object, permeating then to the experience of that artifact. Computer games are designed objects; therefore they can be moral objects.". Thus what we obtain by "gamefying" a thought experiment has the potential to be useful in ethics.

Let me give you some examples of ethically notable games. To be clear, what I proposed ~~before~~ does not necessitate one to actually make a game to make use of a thought experiment, that's the ideal. It will be sufficient for one to keep in mind a well-established gameplay possibility for the thought experiments he or she intends to refer to.

Zagal introduces 4 different levels ethics can relate to computer games:

- Artifact
- Product
- Sport
- Framework